wider horizons after Waterloo and the exile of Napoleon. Originally a native of Zara, south of Trieste on the Dalmatian coast of modern Croatia, Simonitch had joined up with the Grand Armée just in time for the invasion of Russia, and like so many others was taken captive by Tsarist forces on the disastrous midwinter retreat from Moscow. By the time he was released, his homeland had been absorbed into the Austro-Hungarian Empire and he decided to switch sides and join the Russian army. He was given the rank of major, sent to the Georgian grenadier regiment and fought with bravery in the Russo-Persian Wars. Badly wounded in a bayonet charge against the Persian Royal Guard, he was promoted to major-general for his bravery in holding his ground despite his injuries. Soon afterwards, he married an eighteen-year-old widow, Princess Orbeliani, 'the most beautiful woman in Georgia', and in a short time became one of the leading figures in the Russian administration of Tiflis.[4] Transferred as ambassador to Teheran, he soon made it his mission to outmanoeuvre his British counterpart, Sir John MacNeill, who was as resolutely Russophobic as Simonitch was doggedly anti-British.

Since the arrival of Rawlinson and his military mission, Simonitch had managed to gain the Shah's confidence, and achieve far more access and influence than the stolid MacNeill, the former Legation doctor, originally from the Outer Hebrides, who proved no match for Simonitch in terms either of sophistication or of strategy. By 1837 Simonitch had helped nudge the newly crowned Shah to use his British-armed troops to make yet another attack on the disputed city of Herat, offering him a lure of 50,000 gold tomans and the remittance of debt, in return for the Shah's promise to allow the establishment of a Russian legation in Herat once the conquest was completed. It was a brilliant stroke – encouraging the Shah's ambitions in such a way that they threatened British interests in India – and turned the British-trained regiments directly against the interests of their trainers and suppliers. In this way, Simonitch hoped to use the Shah as a cat's paw for the Tsar, though in fact the new Shah, Mohammad II, had anyway been long obsessed with the recapture of Herat – he even mentioned it in his Coronation speech – and needed little Russian encouragement to attempt to retake it.[5]

Simonitch also gave a Russian guarantee to a proposed treaty of mutual defence between the Shah and Dost Mohammad's Barakzai half-brothers in Kandahar. Simonitch was well aware of the effect this would have on